was these self-correcting mechanisms, not the technology of printing, that were the engine of the scientific revolution.

In other words, the scientific revolution was launched by the discovery of ignorance.[91] Religions of the book assumed that they had access to an infallible source of knowledge. The Christians had the Bible, the Muslims had the Quran, the Hindus had the Vedas, and the Buddhists had the Tipitaka. Scientific culture has no comparable holy book, nor does it claim that any of its heroes are infallible prophets, saints or geniuses. The scientific project starts by rejecting the fantasy of infallibility and proceeding to construct an information network that takes error to be inescapable. Sure, there is much talk about the genius of Copernicus, Darwin and Einstein, but none of them is considered faultless. They all made mistakes, and even the most celebrated scientific tracts are sure to contain errors and lacunae.

Since even geniuses suffer from confirmation bias, you cannot trust them to correct their own errors. Science is a team effort, relying on institutional collaboration rather than on individual scientists or, say, a single infallible book. Of course, institutions too are prone to error. Scientific institutions are nevertheless different from religious institutions, inasmuch as they reward scepticism and innovation rather than conformity. Scientific institutions are also different from conspiracy theories, inasmuch as they reward *self*-scepticism. Conspiracy theorists tend to be extremely sceptical regarding the existing consensus, but when it comes to their own beliefs, they lose all their scepticism and fall prey to confirmation bias.[92] The trademark of science is not merely scepticism but self-scepticism, and at the heart of every scientific institution we find a strong self-correcting mechanism. Scientific institutions do reach a broad consensus about the accuracy of certain theories – such as quantum mechanics or the theory of evolution – but only because these theories have managed to survive intense efforts to disprove them, launched not only by outsiders but by members of the institution itself.

SELF-CORRECTING MECHANISMS

As an information technology, the self-correcting mechanism is the polar opposite of the holy book. The holy book is supposed to be infallible. The